

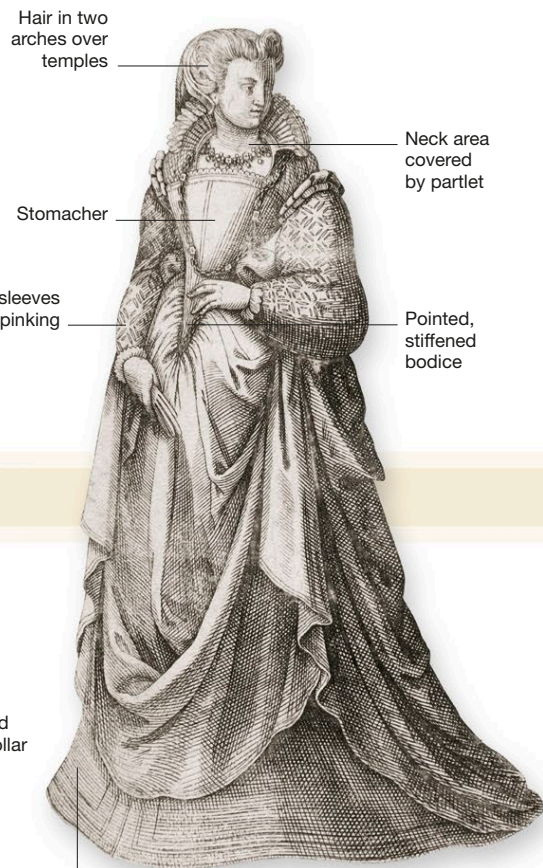
1590–1625

FEMALE GEOMETRY

With the onset of the 17th century every aspect of women's clothes became highly exaggerated – and borrowed heavily from masculine styles. Fashion history's most geometric period created unnatural silhouettes made from straight lines, triangles, and circles. Huge ruffs isolated head from body, or open collars revealed décolletages cut immodestly low. The French farthingale (a wheel-shaped support worn over the hips) made women the widest and squarest they had ever been. It also shortened hems to make feet – in new, heeled shoes – visible for the first time. These skirts marked France's ascent as Europe's fashion leader. Around 1620 a new naturalism appeared and styles relaxed again. By 1625 the long, pointed "bodies" (bodice) had been virtually replaced by a natural waistline, and petticoats took over from farthingales.



Cartwheel ruff Flemish artist Rubens painted his wife, Isabella Brandt, wearing this huge ruff edged with lace. Ruffs achieved their greatest width in the Low Countries, where starching techniques originated. The low, curved bodice front also became a regional style.



Triangular stomacher In the 1580s as the woman's upper garment (bodice) lengthened and the gown opened, the central space was covered with a triangular piece called a stomacher. It was another surface to embellish.

French farthingale Anne of Denmark, the English queen, epitomizes women's fashion in the early 17th century with a low, round neck, transparent, lacy collars and cuffs, and carnation-coloured accents. The farthingale's tabletop effect has transformed her gown's silhouette.

Skirt's length taken up by farthingale; shoes visible for first time